

Rebellion

Arjun had never cared much about birthdays. Forty refused to return the favour. The number had been sitting quietly in the corner of his mind for months—not bothering him, just waiting.

Thirty had arrived with excitement; there had been something heroic about thirty. It came carrying promises: promotions, adventures, countries not yet visited, relationships not yet ruined, lives not yet chosen.

Forty arrived carrying questions.

That morning began like most mornings. At 5:27 a.m., Arjun's eyes opened before the alarm had a chance to announce itself. Years of habit had made the clock mostly symbolic. The apartment was still dark, and London slept behind rain-streaked glass. For a moment he lay still. *Forty*. There it was again. Not fear or sadness, just awareness—like noticing a milestone while driving. You weren't stopping there, but you couldn't pretend you hadn't seen it.

The kettle clicked on. Meditation came first; it always did. Ten years earlier he would have laughed at the idea, but now he sat cross-legged in the small corner of the apartment he had unofficially assigned to silence. Meditation was supposed to help—everybody agreed on that. Most books, most podcasts, most teachers promised a clearer mind, more control, more peace. Arjun liked understanding; it had solved most problems in his life. Not all of them, but most.

He closed his eyes and followed three breaths. *Thought about work. Returned to the breath*. The job was fine—more than fine, really. The bills got paid, his health was good, his daughter was doing well, and his relationship with his former wife had settled into something surprisingly functional. Objectively, life had given him remarkably little to complain about, which was becoming mildly inconvenient.

He followed another breath. Then Maya appeared. That was less convenient. He tried returning to his focus, but his mind immediately ignored the suggestion. For months now, she seemed to appear whenever his mind stopped being occupied—not dramatically, just consistently, like a question that had missed its opportunity to leave.

Maybe things would change. Maybe they wouldn't. Maybe five years from now this would all look obvious. Maybe he was wasting time. Maybe she was the future; maybe she wasn't.

He followed another breath, then another, but the internal conversation continued without him. Meditation was apparently not a legally binding agreement. Eventually, he opened his eyes. Today, that would have to count as enough.

The coffee tasted exactly like yesterday's: strong, predictable, reliable—three qualities Arjun increasingly appreciated. Oats, eggs, a quick scan of the news. The same black mug at the same spot at the dining table. Twenty-three-year-old Arjun would have called it boring; forty-year-old Arjun called it peaceful. At least most days.

His phone buzzed with birthday messages from friends, family, and colleagues who somehow remembered. He scrolled absent-mindedly through jokes about age and warm wishes until one message stood out:

Welcome to the second half.

Arjun laughed, then stopped. *The second half.* The phrase followed him longer than it should have. If this was the second half, what exactly had he done with the first?

That was the annoying thing about forty. It asked inventory questions nobody had invited—quiet questions that appeared while making coffee, arrived during walks, or sat beside you in traffic. They behaved like unwelcome relatives: persistent and difficult to remove.

He looked around the apartment. It was organised, minimal, everything in its place—much like the life he had spent years constructing around career, fitness, responsibility, and discipline. The structure was respectable, even admirable from

the outside. So why did forty feel less like an arrival and more like an audit? Relationships, jobs, cities, missed turns, successful turns, people who stayed, people who left, versions of himself he never became. The mind had started opening old drawers, one after another, uninvited.

His phone buzzed again. Not a birthday message—a reply from the tattoo artist. A smile appeared before he could stop it. Months ago, he had decided that forty deserved something permanent, not because forty was special, but because he was tired of postponing things. His former wife had hated tattoos—not aggressively, just enough. It was one of those small preferences that quietly accumulate over years, a tiny compromise that never feels important individually until suddenly it does.

The plan had been simple: get the tattoo during his next trip to India. Instead, the message contained a surprise. The artist had opened a studio in London, just five kilometres from Arjun’s apartment. He read the message twice and laughed. Life had a strange sense of timing.

Two hours later, he was sitting in the studio. The walls were covered in possibilities—years of postponed ideas surrounding him in symbols, animals, quotes, and patterns. Entire stories waiting beneath skin. He had imagined this moment many times, yet none of the designs felt right until his eyes stopped moving. Three words. Simple, ancient, unreasonably familiar:

Tat Tvam Asi.

The artist noticed his gaze. “That the one?”

Arjun nodded.

“You sure?”

“About tattoos?”

“No,” the artist said, leaning back. “About that tattoo.”

Arjun looked back at the stencil. “I’m reasonably sure.”

The artist laughed. “That’s a dangerous level of certainty for something permanent.”

“That’s probably the most certainty I’ve had all year.”

“Forty?”

Arjun looked up. “That obvious?”

“You booked a Sanskrit tattoo on your fortieth birthday.”

“Fair.”

The artist adjusted the stencil. “So what does it mean?”

“That feels like a trick question,” Arjun said.

“It wasn’t supposed to be.”

“I honestly don’t know.”

The artist laughed. “You’re putting something on your arm forever and you don’t know what it means?”

“I know enough.”

“Which means?”

Arjun thought about it and shrugged. “It feels true.”

The artist stared at him for a moment. “That’s either the best reason or the worst one.”

“Also fair.”

The needle began its work. For the next hour, there was nothing to solve, nothing to optimise, no future to negotiate with—just the strange permanence of something becoming real.

When it was finished, the artist cleaned the skin and stepped back.

“Looks good.”

Arjun nodded. For a moment, neither spoke.

“You’ll be back,” the artist said with a smile.

“For another tattoo?”

“Eventually.”

Arjun laughed. “That sounds like a threat.”

“It’s experience.”

The artist started cleaning his station.

“The funny ones are the people who come in convinced they know exactly what they’re doing.”

“And the rest?”

“The rest come back.”

“Why?”

The artist shrugged. “Because eventually the tattoo stops being the interesting part.”

Arjun looked down at the fresh ink. “What becomes interesting?”

The artist opened the door. “What made them get it in the first place.”

For a moment neither moved. The artist grinned.

“Anyway. That’s next year’s problem.”

Walking home later that afternoon, the fresh tattoo stinging faintly beneath his sleeve, Arjun noticed something strange. He felt lighter. Not happier, not transformed, not wiser.

Just lighter.

As though a tiny rebellion had finally succeeded. Against what exactly, he couldn’t say. Only that something he had delayed for years had quietly become real.

And for reasons he couldn’t explain... that mattered.

Investigation Journal

| *The tattoo mattered more than the birthday. Why?*

